

BOAT MAIL

Until 1964, India and Sri Lanka were linked, not directly, but by train and boat when the Indo-Ceylon Express ran services from Madras (now Chennai) to Colombo. Passengers would board the Rameswaram Express (or Boat Mail) from Madras Egmore and travel through Pamban to a pier at Dhanushkodi, a small village at the very tip of the island of Rameswaram. Here, they would board a ferry run by the Southern Railway, which would take them across the open sea to board a connecting train at Talaimannar in Sri Lanka. The December 1964 cyclone with almost 7-m-high tidal waves, one of the fiercest storms to hit India, destroyed Dhanushkodi, washed away the Pamban bridge, tore up the railway line, and swept away the Pambam–Dhanushkodi passenger train. While international ferry services continued briefly until the mid-80s, the tracks were never repaired.



▲ Remains of the Dhanushkodi town